The scaling policy then increases or decreases the desired capacity of the Auto Scaling group.

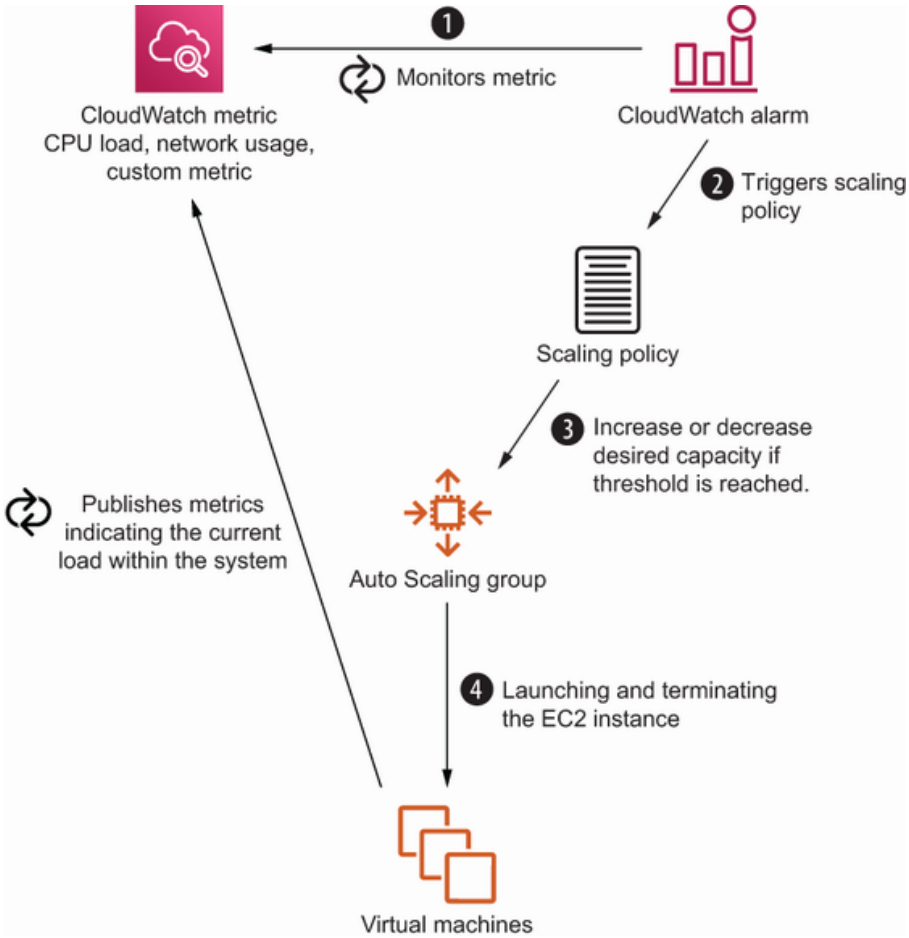


Figure 17.4 Triggering autoscaling based on a CloudWatch metric and alarm

An EC2 instance publishes several metrics to CloudWatch by default: CPU, network, and disk utilization are the most important. Unfortunately, no metric currently exists for a virtual machine's memory usage. You can use these metrics to scale the number of VMs if a bottleneck is reached. For example, you can add EC2 instances if the CPU is working to capacity. The following parameters describe a CloudWatch metric:

- `Namespace`—Defines the source of the metric (such as AWS/EC2)
- `Dimensions`—Defines the scope of the metric (such as all virtual machines belonging to an Auto Scaling group)
- `MetricName`—Unique name of the metric (such as `CPUUtilization`)